



Old allies

Conference delegates included (left to right) British Foreign Secretary Sir Anthony Eden, US Under Secretary of State Walter Bedell Smith, and French Foreign Minister Georges Bidault.

Dividing line

The Geneva Accords, issued on July 21, 1954, separated the warring forces. All Viet Minh troops were to regroup north of the 17th parallel—an arbitrary line agreed to after much haggling—while the French withdrew to its south. A timetable was set for all French troops to quit Vietnam. The final declaration of the conference insisted that the 17th parallel was not to be seen as a political border. Elections were to be held within two years to unify Vietnam under a democratic government. However, the United States was not a signatory of the Accords; nor was the State of Vietnam, where the nationalist Ngo Dinh Diem had just been appointed prime minister. The Geneva Accords left the future of Vietnam dangerously undecided.

“The **military demarcation line** is a temporary one and may in **no way** be seen as a **political or territorial border.**”

FINAL GENEVA DECLARATION, ON THE DIVISION OF VIETNAM, JULY 1954